realization that these have made much headway. The real question is the ability of the US to reassess and reinvent itself. What this means to the world is a new kind of diplomacy, one more in tune with an awareness of its limitations and, consequently, of the value of greater and more contemporary partnerships.

Even as all of this happens, the world also witnesses the rise of China. Indeed, this correlation between the fortunes of the two nations is difficult to dispute. The emergence of a power at a global level is a unique happening in any circumstance. That this is a ‘different’ kind of polity, both ideologically and culturally, enhances the sense of change. The Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) may have borne some similarities, but it never had the salience to the global economy that China has today. We are, therefore, contemplating scenarios very different from the post-1945 situation.

The consequences of China’s growing capabilities are particularly significant because of the extrapolation of its domestic seamlessness to the world outside. As a result, whether it is connectivity, technology or trade, there is now an ongoing debate on the changed nature of power and influence. Separately, we have also seen a sharpening of tensions on territorial issues across the breadth of Asia. Agreements and understandings of yesteryears now seem to have developed question marks. India had its own experiences, especially in 2020, with regard to the border situation.

Time will, of course, provide more answers. But what is evident is that establishing a multipolar Asia as a foundation of a multipolar world is now more urgent than before. Obviously, much of this will happen in the backdrop of intensified great power competition, and understanding how that could unfold is, therefore, vital. Here too, the Ramayana has some instructive insights.

Among the backstories of the Ramayana is the competition between two sages, one who can be regarded as an entrenched power and the other as a rising one. Their rivalry originated in an attempt by King Kaushika to forcibly seize Sage Vasistha’s particularly productive cow. In the fight that followed, all his sons and his entire army were destroyed. Kaushika then acquired formidable weapons through penance but was again unsuccessful in his attacks on Vasistha. He then intensified his prayers and steadily moved up the ranks of the sages. But in the process, he discovered that rising